MA ENGLISH • SEMESTER 1

Block 1 — Unit 4: Shakespearean Criticism and Poetry

SHAKESPEARE STUDIES • M21EG02DC

Expanded exam notes | Simple teaching + developed argument

Based on the supplied SGOU self-learning material. Use the assigned primary texts for exact quotations and full scene or passage analysis.

The chapter in one sentence

Critics ask different questions of Shakespeare, and the sonnets show why form, language, feeling, and uncertainty all deserve attention.

Start with a picture

Several people examine the same house. One studies its rooms, another its foundations, another who can enter. They see the same building through different questions. Literary criticism similarly selects an angle; a persuasive interpretation must still explain evidence.

1. Keats and Lamb

Keats's **negative capability** means an ability to remain with uncertainty and doubt without rushing to a forced explanation. Shakespeare becomes an example of imaginative openness to differing experiences.

Charles Lamb questioned whether theatrical performance could fully convey the inward imaginative experience of some Shakespearean plays. Treat this as a particular critical argument, not a settled proof that Shakespeare should never be performed.

2. Bradley and Eliot

A. C. Bradley analyses tragic character, conflict, action, and suffering. His approach encourages detailed attention to motivation but can be criticised if characters are detached too far from language and performance.

T. S. Eliot's **objective correlative** concerns a set of objects, situations, or events capable of conveying an emotion adequately. In his famous criticism of Hamlet, he argues that the dramatic circumstances do not fully account for the hero's emotion. This controversial judgement differs from simply calling Hamlet indecisive.

3. Imagery, ambiguity, and language

G. Wilson Knight emphasises patterns of imagery, symbolism, and the imaginative worlds created by plays. William Empson makes **ambiguity**, the coexistence of meanings, central to interpretation. An ambiguous expression is not necessarily careless writing.

Leslie Stephen, Frank Kermode, and other critics extend debates about character, language, intellectual context, and dramatic achievement. Learn a critic through an argument and an example, not a name alone.

4. Ideology and power

Terry Eagleton and Jonathan Dollimore encourage attention to language, social order, ideology, and the contradictions within authority. **Ideology** refers to organised assumptions through which social relations appear natural or justified. A play can participate in an ideology while also exposing its tensions.

5. The sonnet’s basic design

A Shakespearean sonnet usually has fourteen lines arranged as three quatrains and a couplet, with rhyme ABAB CDCD EFEF GG. The usual metre is iambic pentameter. A **quatrain** has four lines; a **couplet** has two.

The arrangement can develop, challenge, and revise an argument. A **volta** is a turn of thought; its location and force vary. The final couplet may conclude, qualify, or complicate earlier claims.

6. Subjects and identities

The 1609 collection contains 154 numbered sonnets exploring beauty, love, jealousy, time, mortality, and poetry. “Fair Youth” and “Dark Lady” are conventional labels used in discussion. Their exact historical identities remain uncertain; the speaker is not automatically an unfiltered autobiographical Shakespeare.

Quick check

1. Does negative capability mean having no ability? **No; it names an imaginative capacity to tolerate uncertainty.**
2. Does ambiguity necessarily mean confusion? **No; several meanings may operate deliberately.**
3. Is Eliot’s judgement on Hamlet universally accepted? **No; it is an influential, contested argument.**

Build an exam answer

1. State that approaches select different problems.
2. Explain Bradley with a tragic example.
3. Contrast Eliot’s demand for dramatic embodiment.
4. Add imagery or ambiguity as a formal method.
5. Evaluate what a power-centred reading contributes.

Common mistake to avoid

Keep critics' views distinct and attribute controversial claims. Avoid treating the Fair Youth and Dark Lady labels as proven identifications.

Developed exam discussion

Practice question

Compare character-centred, formal, and ideological approaches to Shakespeare.

Explain the argument in fuller paragraphs

The history of Shakespearean criticism demonstrates that interpretation is shaped by the questions readers ask. A character-centred approach, associated prominently with Bradley, investigates motives, decisions, and tragic suffering. It can illuminate the inward conflicts that make a protagonist compelling. Its limitation emerges when a fictional character is treated as an independently living person rather than a figure created through dramatic language and action.

Eliot shifts attention towards the relation between emotion and its dramatic embodiment. His discussion of the objective correlative asks whether the play supplies an adequate arrangement of circumstances for the feeling it presents. Whether or not a reader accepts his conclusion about Hamlet, the method directs attention to artistic construction rather than biography or sympathy alone.

Formal approaches can investigate imagery, patterns of language, and ambiguity. Knight's interest in a play's symbolic atmosphere and Empson's concern with multiple meanings reveal effects that a plot summary would miss. Ideological approaches ask a different but compatible set of questions: how do texts organise authority, social rank, gender, and exclusion? Such criticism does not require ignoring aesthetic form, since the distribution of speech and the shape of an ending may themselves carry political implications.

An effective comparison avoids declaring one method correct in every case. Instead, apply two approaches to a specific scene and explain what each reveals or overlooks. The purpose of studying critics is to gain analytical resources, not to replace reading with borrowed conclusions.

How to use this discussion

Adapt the argument to the exact wording and marks of your question. Use one point per paragraph and support it with a scene, line, image, or formal detail. Verify exact quotations in the assigned text. The discussion is explanatory paraphrase, not a quotation or a guaranteed model answer.

Textbook assignment checklist

These are the unit's assignment prompts for revision. They are not predictions or a set of fully written assignment submissions.

1. Explain the concept of "negative capability" and analyse its presence in Shakespearean characters.

2. Compare the critical perspectives of Bradley and Eliot on Hamlet.
3. Discuss the role of symbolism and imagery in Shakespeare’s tragedies as interpreted by critics.
4. Analyse the form and thematic concerns of Shakespeare’s sonnets, focusing on the “Fair Youth” and “Dark Lady.”
5. Critically evaluate contemporary ideological perspectives on Shakespeare’s plays, such as feminist or Marxist readings.